

As a scientist, I see sharing knowledge—especially with the next generation—as part of my responsibility. As a mathematics educator, I want students to build problem-solving skills, understand mathematics beyond computation, and communicate their reasoning clearly.

Teaching Experience

My teaching experience began in 2022 at Clemson University, where I worked as a teaching assistant across several areas of mathematics. Those three years strengthened my ability to communicate with students individually and in small groups, and taught me to look beyond an incorrect answer to understand what might be making a concept difficult. Some students arrive believing mathematics is inherently difficult; past experiences can also make asking questions feel risky. Others struggle to see the subject's relevance beyond the classroom. In a Fall 2022 Business Calculus II course, one student described me as approachable and wrote, “he never made me feel dumb”.

Since Fall 2025, I have taught my own sections. I began with Essential Mathematics for the Informed Society (MATH 1010), a flipped, coordinated course. Although the class was relatively small, teaching it showed me how challenging it can be to communicate concepts clearly to an entire class and engage students as a group. The experience prompted me to think more carefully about how to make participation and questions feel welcome.

In Spring 2026, I taught coordinated precalculus using materials provided by the course coordinator. I focused class time on core concepts students needed for homework and exams, then used examples and applications to invite them to consider broader ideas. I reminded students that understanding does not have to happen all at once, and offered office hours at flexible times when their class or work schedules conflicted. Student feedback included:

- “Sitiraka was always asking us to engage with any questions we had about anything. He was very helpful and clear about assignments, and was willing to work with us if we were struggling.”
- “Really good teacher, helped me understand derivatives.”

Other feedback identified clarity and pacing as areas for growth, which informs my efforts to write clearer materials and communicate more deliberately in class.

One student who earned a low grade on the first exam regularly attended office hours and earned a very good grade on the final. I cannot attribute that progress to any single factor, but the experience showed me how classroom instruction, individual support, and student effort can work together to support learning.

I am currently teaching coordinated one-variable calculus, where I develop my own notes and contribute to the coursework. The graded coursework focuses on core expectations, while optional bonus problems invite further exploration. For example, students can investigate limit calculations to understand how and why L'Hôpital's rule works.

Teaching Philosophy

I believe every student should have the opportunity to engage with mathematics and develop strong problem-solving skills in an environment that supports their well-being. I aim to pair meaningful intellectual challenges with clear expectations, time to think, and reassurance that struggle is a

normal part of learning. I make expectations explicit, distinguishing what students need for the course from ideas that may be useful in future study or work.

To check understanding, I offer a brief, similar problem and ask whether students would like to try it right away or take more time to think. At the beginning of the next class, I recap the previous material and invite questions, recognizing that new concepts can take time to absorb. I also remind students that I was a student before becoming a teacher and encourage them to reach out. I see sharing knowledge as a responsibility and teaching as a way to make mathematical ideas more accessible.

Looking Forward

In a postdoctoral role, I hope to contribute to undergraduate mathematics teaching while continuing to refine my practice. I want to strengthen in-class interaction and improve how I write course materials so that mathematical ideas are clearer and easier to follow. I plan to use brief, low-stakes conceptual activities to check understanding without adding a heavy workload. For instance, students might describe what they know about vertical, horizontal, and slant asymptotes, then reason about how these features can occur together in a function.

I also want to improve my time management so I can prepare these activities and support students sustainably. Ultimately, I hope students leave my courses more confident in their ability to think critically, apply mathematics to their lives, and understand the concepts they have studied.